Chapter 8 — Styling React Apps

React has no built-in styling system: it renders HTML elements and you style them with CSS. The question is *how you write,* ***scope*** *(limit which elements a rule can affect) and ship* that CSS. This chapter compares the approaches in real codebases, runs each, and helps you choose. It assumes CSS basics (selectors; the cascade — which conflicting declaration wins; specificity — selector "strength"; custom properties — CSS variables such as `--accent`); otherwise read the HTML & CSS book first — CSS fundamentals and modern CSS & architecture.

Code: `code/`. Node programs print what React puts in the DOM; visuals are screenshots of real pages in **headless** Chrome (no window, script-driven), bundled with esbuild, with Tailwind compiled by the Tailwind v4.3 **CLI** (command-line interface).

8.1 The styling landscape

The problem every approach solves

CSS was designed for documents: every rule is **global**, and conflicts are settled by the **cascade** (origin — browser default vs your stylesheet, specificity, order). In an app of hundreds of components that causes three pains:

1. **Name collisions** — two teams both write `.title`; the last-loaded file wins.
2. **Dead CSS** — nobody dares delete a rule because nobody knows who still uses it.
3. **Dynamic styles** — colours or sizes depending on props and state.

Family	How you write styles	Scoping	Runtime cost (extra browser work while the app runs)	Typical tools
Global CSS files	`.css` files, `className="card"`	Naming conventions (BEM, §8.2)	None	Plain CSS, Sass (a CSS preprocessor adding variables, nesting and mixins)
Inline styles	`style={{ color: 'red' }}`	Per element	Tiny	Built into React
CSS Modules	`.module.css`, `className={styles.card}`	Automatic, per file	None	Vite, Next.js, webpack
Utility-first CSS	`className="p-4 rounded-xl bg-white"`	Nothing to scope — classes are single-purpose	None	**Tailwind CSS**, UnoCSS
CSS-in-JS	Styles in JS (`styled.div\`…\``)	Automatic, generated names	Runtime libs: yes; zero-runtime: none	styled-components, Emotion; vanilla-extract, StyleX, Panda

The same card styled five ways (`code/gallery.html`, components in `code/cards.jsx`):

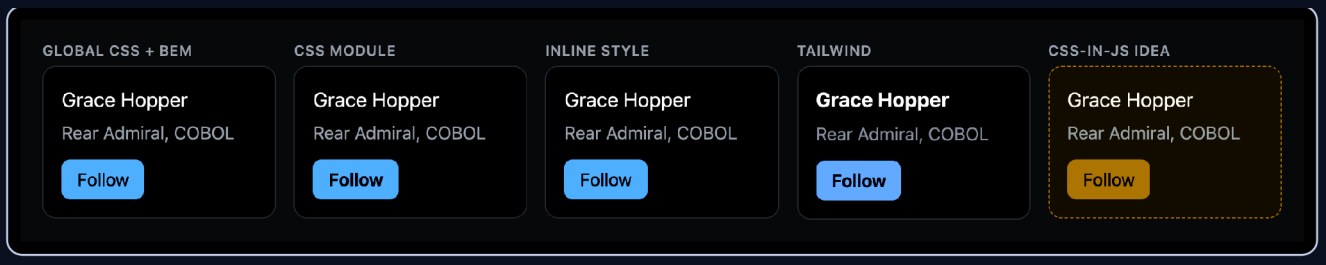


*Figure 8.1 — One component, five styling approaches. The output is ordinary HTML + CSS in every case; they differ in how the CSS is authored, scoped and delivered. (The Tailwind heading uses an explicit `font-bold` — Tailwind's **reset** (a stylesheet that wipes the browser's default styles), "Preflight", removes default heading styles on the whole page, which is why the other headings look lighter than browser defaults.)*

8.2 Plain CSS files

What it is

Write rules in a `.css` file and apply them with `className` (not `class`, a reserved word in JavaScript — §1.8). With a **bundler** (combines source files and their imports into browser files) such as Vite you can `import './Card.css'` from a component; the bundler adds it to the page.

```jsx
// cards.jsx
import './global.css';
export function GlobalCssCard({ name, role }) {
  const [following, setFollowing] = useState(false);
  return (
    <div className="profile-card">
      <h3 className="profile-card__name">{name}</h3>
      <p className="profile-card__role">{role}</p>
      <button className={cx('profile-card__button', following && 'profile-card__button--following')}
              onClick={() => setFollowing(f => !f)}>{following ? 'Following' : 'Follow'}</button>
    </div>
  );
}
```

```css
/* global.css — BEM naming keeps selectors from colliding by convention only. */
.profile-card { border: 1px solid #d0d7de; border-radius: 12px; padding: 16px; background: #fff; }
.profile-card__name { margin: 0 0 4px; font-size: 18px; }
.profile-card__button:hover { background: #0550ae; }
.profile-card__button--following { background: #eaeef2; color: #24292f; }
```

How it works

1. `import './global.css'` is a **bundler feature**, not JavaScript: imported CSS is collected into the page (a `<link>` in production, injected `<style>` in dev).
2. **Importing CSS in a component does not scope it** — the rules apply to the *whole page*, even to components that never imported the file.
3. Teams avoid collisions with naming conventions such as **BEM** (Block__Element--Modifier): `profile-card` (block), `profile-card__name` (element), `profile-card__button--following` (modifier).

Trade-offs

✅ Strengths	❌ Weaknesses
Zero tooling, zero runtime, full CSS power (`:hover` , media/container queries — rules for certain screen or container sizes, animations, nesting, `@layer`)	Global by default — scoping is only as good as your discipline
Easy for designers and CSS experts	Hard to know if a rule is still used; dead CSS accumulates
Browser caches the stylesheet separately from JS	Dynamic values need CSS variables or inline styles

Modern CSS removed much of the old pain: **native nesting**, **cascade layers** (`@layer` — decide which group of rules wins regardless of specificity) and **custom properties** work in current browsers (HTML & CSS book, Chapter 13). Sass is still common but no longer needed for variables or nesting.

React 19: stylesheets as components

Render `<link rel="stylesheet" href="/card.css" precedence="default" />` anywhere and React moves it into `<head>` , loads it once even if many components render it, orders it by `precedence` , and — inside a Suspense boundary (`<Suspense>` shows a fallback while content isn't ready) — waits for it before revealing the content. Mostly used by frameworks and libraries; a Vite app normally just `import` s CSS.

TL;DR

`className` + CSS file. Imports are global — use a naming convention or move to CSS Modules.

8.3 Inline styles — the `style` prop

What it is

Every HTML element accepts a `style` **prop**: an object whose keys are CSS properties in **camelCase** (`backgroundColor` , not `background-color`). React writes it to the element's `style` attribute. In `style={{ … }}` the outer braces are a JSX expression, the inner an object literal.

`code/01_inline_styles.jsx` :

```jsx
function ProgressBar({ percent, color = 'seagreen' }) {
  return (
    <div style={{ background: '#eee', borderRadius: 4, height: 8 }}>            {/* numbers -> px */}
      <div style={{ width: `${percent}%`, height: '100%', backgroundColor: color, borderRadius: 4 }} />
    </div>
  );
}

function Examples() {
  return (
    <>
      <ProgressBar percent={40} />
      <p style={{ lineHeight: 1.5, zIndex: 2, opacity: 0.8, flexGrow: 1 }}>unitless properties stay unitless</p>
      <p style={{ '--accent': 'tomato', color: 'var(--accent)' }}>CSS custom property set inline</p>
      <p style={{ WebkitLineClamp: 2, msTransform: 'none' }}>vendor prefixes</p>
      <p style={{ ':hover': { color: 'red' }, '@media (max-width: 600px)': { display: 'none' } }}>no pseudo-
classes or media queries</p>
    </>
  );
}
```

Output (real `style` attributes; the first line is React's dev warning):

```
Unsupported style property @media (max-width: 600px). Did you mean @media (maxWidth: 600px)?
<div style="background: rgb(238, 238, 238); border-radius: 4px; height: 8px;">
<div style="width: 40%; height: 100%; background-color: seagreen; border-radius: 4px;">
<p style="line-height: 1.5; z-index: 2; opacity: 0.8; flex-grow: 1;">
<p style="--accent: tomato; color: var(--accent);">
<p style="-webkit-line-clamp: 2;">
```

How it works — the rules the output shows

1. **Numbers get `px`** for lengths (`borderRadius: 4` → `4px`), but **unitless properties** (`lineHeight`, `zIndex`, `opacity`, `flexGrow`, …) stay plain. Other units: strings (`'50%'`, `'2rem'`).
2. **Custom properties** (`'--accent'`) pass through unchanged — the cleanest way to feed a dynamic value into a stylesheet.
3. **Vendor prefixes** (browser-specific prefixes such as `-webkit-` from when features were experimental) start with a capital (`WebkitLineClamp`), except `ms` (`msTransform`). (jsdom, like modern browsers, dropped the obsolete `-ms-transform`.)
4. **Pseudo-classes (`:hover`), pseudo-elements (`::before`), media queries and keyframes are impossible**: a `style` attribute can't hold selectors or at-rules (`@…` statements). The last `<p>` got no style, and React warned.

When to use it (and when not)

Use inline styles for	Don't use them for
Values computed at runtime: progress width, drag position, a user-chosen colour	Whole-component styling (no hover/focus/responsive; hard to override)
Passing a value to CSS: `style={{ '--progress': ${p}% }}` with the rest in a stylesheet	Anything a designer will want to theme
Quick prototypes	Large lists where every row repeats the same object (use a class)

Inline styles have the **highest specificity** of normal declarations — a stylesheet can override them only with `!important`, another reason to reserve them for truly dynamic values.

TL;DR

`style={{ camelCase: value }}`; numbers → px except unitless properties; no `:hover` or media queries. Best for dynamic values, ideally via CSS variables.

8.4 CSS Modules

What it is

A **CSS Module** (`*.module.css`) has class names **local to the file that imports it**: the build tool renames every class uniquely and gives JavaScript an object mapping original to generated names. Normal CSS, no collisions. Supported out of the box by Vite, Next.js, Parcel, webpack's `css-loader` and esbuild.

`code/Card.module.css`:

```
.card { border: 1px solid #d0d7de; border-radius: 12px; padding: 16px; background: #fff; }
.title { margin: 0 0 4px; font-size: 18px; }
.role { margin: 0 0 12px; color: #57606a; }
.button { font: inherit; padding: 6px 14px; border-radius: 8px; border: 0; background: #0969da; color: #fff;
cursor: pointer; }
.button:hover { background: #0550ae; }
.primary { composes: button; font-weight: 600; }       /* reuse another class */
:global(.sr-only) { position: absolute; width: 1px; height: 1px; overflow: hidden; clip: rect(0 0 0 0); } /*
escape hatch */
```

Using it (`code/cards.jsx`):

```jsx
import styles from './Card.module.css';
export function ModuleCard({ name, role }) {
  return (
    <div className={styles.card}>
      <h3 className={styles.title}>{name}</h3>
      <p className={styles.role}>{role}</p>
      <button className={styles.primary}>Follow</button>
    </div>
  );
}
```

`code/02_css_modules.mjs` runs esbuild on that file (bundling `import styles from './Card.module.css'` and printing the object and emitted CSS):

```
--- the JS object you get from `import styles from "./Card.module.css"` ---
{ card: "Card_card", title: "Card_title", role: "Card_role", button: "Card_button", primary: "Card_button
Card_primary" }
--- the CSS the bundler emits (renamed, so it cannot clash) ---
.Card_card {
  border: 1px solid #d0d7de;
  border-radius: 12px;
  padding: 16px;
  background: #fff;
}
.Card_title {
  margin: 0 0 4px;
  font-size: 18px;
}
... (role, button and button:hover renamed the same way)
.Card_primary {
  font-weight: 600;
}
.sr-only {
  position: absolute;
  ...
}
```

How it works

1. Each class selector is renamed: `.card` → `.Card_card` (esbuild's scheme; Vite and webpack add a short **hash** computed from the content, e.g. `_card_1x9ab_1`, so names are unique even across same-named files).
2. `import styles from …` returns the mapping; `styles.card` is the generated string.
3. **`composes: button`** makes `styles.primary` *both* names — `"Card_button Card_primary"` — reuse without duplicated rules.
4. **`:global(.sr-only)`** opts a selector out of renaming.
5. Only class names are scoped — element selectors (`h3 { … }`) and IDs are not — so keep module files to classes.

Trade-offs

✅	❌
Real CSS: hover, media/container queries, animations, nesting	Styles live in a second file (some like this, some don't)
Zero runtime, works with Server Components (Chapter 13)	Dynamic values still need CSS variables or inline styles
Unused-class detection with TypeScript plugins / linters	Class names with dashes need bracket access: `styles['is-active']` (or configure camelCase conversion)
Easy migration from plain CSS	Theming across modules relies on CSS variables (§8.8)

Common mistakes

- Naming the file `Card.css` (no `.module`) → nothing scoped, `styles` empty.
- `className="card"` instead of `className={styles.card}` → no style (the real name was changed).
- A non-existent class → `styles.tittle` is `undefined` and React silently renders `class` without it. TypeScript typings for modules catch this.

TL;DR

`*.module.css` + `styles.x`. Local class names, real CSS, no runtime. A safe default for teams that like writing CSS.

8.5 Composing class names from props

What it is

Components choose classes from props and state (a Button's `variant`, `size`, `loading`, plus an extra `className` from its parent). Building the string with `+` and ternaries is error-prone; the tiny `clsx` package (and older `classnames`) does it. `code/cx.js` is a 10-line version — no magic:

```
// cx('a', cond && 'b', { c: true, d: false }, ['e', null]) -> 'a b c e'
export function cx(...args) {
  const out = [];
  for (const a of args) {
    if (!a) continue;                                  // false, null, undefined, 0, ''
    if (typeof a === 'string' || typeof a === 'number') out.push(a);
    else if (Array.isArray(a)) { const inner = cx(...a); if (inner) out.push(inner); }
    else if (typeof a === 'object') for (const [k, v] of Object.entries(a)) if (v) out.push(k);
  }
  return out.join(' ');
}
```

`code/03_class_names.jsx`:

```
function Button({ variant = 'primary', size = 'md', loading = false, className, ...rest }) {
  return (
    <button
      className={cx('btn', `btn--${variant}`, `btn--${size}`, { 'btn--loading': loading }, className)}
      disabled={loading || rest.disabled}
      {...rest}
    />
  );
}
// <Button>Save</Button>  <Button variant="danger" size="sm">Delete</Button>
// <Button loading>Uploading</Button>  <Button variant="ghost" className="ml-auto">Cancel</Button>
```

Output:

```
"btn active lg"
Save      class="btn btn--primary btn--md"
Delete    class="btn btn--danger btn--sm"
Uploading class="btn btn--primary btn--md btn--loading" disabled
Cancel    class="btn btn--ghost btn--md ml-auto"
concatenated: "btn false undefined"
```

The last line is the bug `clsx` prevents: naive concatenation leaks `"false"` and `"undefined"` into the DOM.

Patterns worth knowing

- **Always accept and merge a `className` prop** in reusable components, so parents can add spacing/layout (`ml-auto`) without **forking** (copying and modifying) the component.

- **Variant maps** beat nested ternaries: `const VARIANTS = { primary: '…', danger: '…' }` then `VARIANTS[variant]`; **`cva`** (class-variance-authority) formalises this for Tailwind.
- **With CSS Modules**: `cx(styles.btn, styles[variant], loading && styles.loading)`.
- **With Tailwind**, conflicting utilities (`px-2` from the component, `px-4` from the parent) are *not* resolved by string order; use **`tailwind-merge`** (`twMerge(clsx(...))`) so the last wins (§8.6).

In a real project: `npm install clsx` and `import { clsx } from 'clsx'` — same API for these cases.

TL;DR

Build class strings with `clsx` / `cx`; accept a `className` prop; use variant maps instead of ternary chains.

8.6 Tailwind CSS

What it is

Tailwind CSS is a **utility-first** framework: instead of inventing class names and writing rules, you compose tiny single-purpose classes in your **markup** — `p-4` (padding), `rounded-xl`, `bg-white`, `text-gray-500`, `hover:bg-blue-700`. A build step scans your source and generates CSS for **only the classes you use**. Current major version: **v4** (released January 2025; v4.3 at the time of writing), configured in CSS rather than a JavaScript config file.

The Tailwind card from Figure 8.1:

```
export function TailwindCard({ name, role }) {
  return (
    <div className="rounded-xl border border-gray-300 bg-white p-4">
      <h3 className="mb-1 text-lg font-bold">{name}</h3>
      <p className="mb-3 text-gray-500">{role}</p>
      <button className="rounded-lg bg-blue-600 px-3.5 py-1.5 font-semibold text-white hover:bg-blue-
700">Follow</button>
    </div>
  );
}
```

How it works

1. One line in your main CSS, `@import "tailwindcss";`, brings in the default **theme** (colours, spacing, fonts as CSS variables), **Preflight** (a CSS reset) and the **utilities** layer.
2. The build tool (Vite plugin or CLI) scans source files for anything that looks like a class name; `@source "./path"` adds places it wouldn't find.
3. Each recognised class generates one rule. Variants are prefixes: `hover:`, `focus-visible:`, `md:` (screen ≥ 48rem = 768px; `rem` is relative to the root font size, usually 16px), `dark:`, `disabled:`, `group-hover:` …
4. Values come from the theme (`px-2` = 2 × `--spacing`), or an **arbitrary value** in brackets: `w-[37px]`, `grid-cols-[1fr_2fr]`.

`code/05_tailwind_build.mjs` runs the real Tailwind CLI on:

```
<span className="px-2 font-semibold hover:bg-blue-700 md:text-lg dark:text-white w-[37px]">new</span>
```

Output (only these utilities out of thousands possible):

```
@layer utilities {
  .w-\[37px\] {
    width: 37px;
  }
  .px-2 {
    padding-inline: calc(var(--spacing) * 2);
  }
  .font-semibold {
    --tw-font-weight: var(--font-weight-semibold);
    font-weight: var(--font-weight-semibold);
  }
  @media (hover: hover) {
    .hover\:bg-blue-700:hover {
      background-color: var(--color-blue-700);
    }
  }
  @media (width >= 48rem) {
    .md\:text-lg {
      font-size: var(--text-lg);
      line-height: var(--tw-leading, var(--text-lg--line-height));
    }
  }
  @media (prefers-color-scheme: dark) {
    .dark\:text-white {
      color: var(--color-white);
    }
  }
}
```

Variants become ordinary CSS (media queries, `:hover`); `hover:` applies only on devices that can hover (v4 behaviour); every value points at a theme variable — change `--color-blue-700` once and every use follows.

Setting it up (Vite — not run here)

```
npm install tailwindcss @tailwindcss/vite
```

```
// vite.config.js
import { defineConfig } from 'vite';
import react from '@vitejs/plugin-react';
import tailwindcss from '@tailwindcss/vite';
export default defineConfig({ plugins: [react(), tailwindcss()] });
```

```
/* src/index.css */
@import "tailwindcss";

@theme {                                /* your design tokens -> new utilities */
  --color-brand: oklch(0.55 0.2 260);     /* enables bg-brand, text-brand, border-brand… */
  --font-display: "Inter", sans-serif;    /* enables font-display */
}
@custom-variant dark (&:where(.dark, .dark *));   /* optional: dark: follows a .dark class instead of the OS */
```

(Here the CLI did the same job: `tailwindcss -i tailwind.input.css -o tailwind.css` produced `code/tailwind.css` for the screenshot.)

Reusing styles: components, not `@apply`

Reuse long class lists by making a **component** (`<Button>`, `<Card>`) — the intended way in React. `@apply` (copying utilities into a custom class) brings back naming and dead-CSS problems; use it sparingly (e.g. styling Markdown output you don't control).

Common mistakes

Mistake	Why it fails	Fix
`className={`bg-${color}-500`}`	The scanner reads source *text*; it never sees `bg-red-500`, so no CSS is generated	Map to complete class names: `{ red: 'bg-red-500', green: 'bg-green-500' }[color]`
`className="px-2 px-4"` expecting px-4 to win	Winner is decided by order *in the generated CSS*, not in the attribute	Don't pass conflicting classes; merge with `tailwind-merge`
Forgetting Preflight resets headings, lists, buttons	`<h1>` looks like body text	Style explicitly (`text-3xl font-bold`) — intended
Huge unreadable class strings	Hard to review	Extract components; order with the official Prettier (code formatter) plugin

Trade-offs

✅	❌
No naming, no switching files, no dead CSS (unused classes are never generated)	Markup gets long and noisy
Consistent design tokens (named design values such as colours and spacing; §8.8) out of the box	A new vocabulary to learn; team must agree to use it
Tiny production CSS that stops growing with the app	Dynamic values need arbitrary values or CSS variables
Zero runtime; works with Server Components	Styles are coupled to markup — harder to restyle a whole app by editing one stylesheet (use theme variables)

Tailwind is the default in many starter kits (`create-next-app` offers it; shadcn/ui is built on it) and widely used by teams valuing iteration speed.

In the interview

30-second answer: "Tailwind is utility-first: I compose small classes like `p-4 rounded-xl hover:bg-blue-700` in JSX, and the build scans my files and generates only the CSS I used, so there's no naming, no dead CSS and no runtime. Reuse happens through React components. The traps are dynamically-built class names, which the scanner can't see, and conflicting utilities, which need `tailwind-merge` . v4 configures the theme in CSS with `@theme` ."

- *Why won't `` `text-${size}` `` work?* — The scanner only sees complete class names in source text.

TL;DR

Utilities in JSX, CSS generated from what you use. Write complete class names, reuse via components, configure with `@theme` .

8.7 CSS-in-JS

What it is

CSS-in-JS = styles written in JavaScript, usually **colocated** with the component and able to use props:

```
// styled-components / Emotion style (not run — not installed)
import styled from 'styled-components';
const Button = styled.button`
  padding: 6px 14px;
  border-radius: 8px;
  background: ${props => (props.$danger ? 'crimson' : '#0969da')};
  &:hover { filter: brightness(0.9); }
`;
<Button $danger>Delete</Button>
```

Kind	How it works	Examples
Runtime	In the browser, the library turns the template (the **tagged template literal** after `styled.button`) into CSS, hashes it into a class name, and injects a `<style>` tag while rendering	styled-components, Emotion
Zero-runtime (build-time)	A compiler extracts the styles into static `.css` files during the build; only class names remain in JS	vanilla-extract, Linaria, Panda CSS, StyleX (Meta)

How runtime CSS-in-JS works — a tiny version

`code/cards.jsx` has a 5-line imitation using a React 19 feature: a `<style>` with `href` and `precedence` is **hoisted into `<head>` and de-duplicated** by React, however many components render it.

```
function css(strings) { /* hash the text into a class name, replace & with .className */ }
const cardStyle = css`& { border: 1px dashed #bf8700; border-radius: 12px; padding: 16px; background: #fff8c5; }
  & h3 { margin: 0 0 4px; font-size: 18px; } & p { margin: 0 0 12px; color: #57606a; }
  & button { font: inherit; padding: 6px 14px; border-radius: 8px; border: 0; background: #bf8700; color: #fff;
}`;

export function CssInJsCard({ name, role }) {
  return (
    <div className={cardStyle.id}>
      <style href={cardStyle.id} precedence="medium">{cardStyle.text}</style>
      <h3>{name}</h3><p>{role}</p><button>Follow</button>
    </div>
  );
}
```

That is the yellow card in Figure 8.1. Real libraries add prop interpolation, theming, vendor prefixing and server-side extraction — and must insert styles *before* layout effects read the DOM, hence React's library-author Hook `useInsertionEffect` (§5.11).

Why the trend moved away from runtime CSS-in-JS

1. **Runtime cost**: **serialising** style objects to CSS text and hashing during render adds work every render, and injected rules force style recalculation.
2. **Server Components** (Chapter 13): runtime libraries rely on context and client-side rendering, so styled components must live in `'use client'` files.
3. **Streaming SSR** (HTML sent in chunks as ready) needs extra setup to collect styles per request.

In **March 2025 styled-components entered maintenance mode** (bug and security fixes only); its maintainer advised against adopting it for new projects. Existing apps keep working, and Emotion remains widely used (e.g. inside MUI). New projects mostly choose CSS Modules, Tailwind, or a **zero-runtime** library keeping colocated, typed authoring without the runtime.

Trade-offs

✅	❌
Styles next to the component; dynamic styles from props	Runtime libs: slower renders, bigger bundles, RSC (React Server Components) friction
Automatic scoping; dead styles die with the component	Another abstraction to learn; debugging generated class names
Zero-runtime libs: type-safe tokens, static CSS output	Zero-runtime libs need build-tool plugins

TL;DR

Runtime CSS-in-JS (styled-components, Emotion) is convenient but costs render time and clashes with Server Components; zero-runtime tools (vanilla-extract, StyleX, Panda) or CSS Modules/Tailwind are the usual picks for new work.

8.8 Theming and dark mode

What it is

Theming switches a whole set of design values (colours, radii, fonts) at once. The modern, framework-independent way: **CSS custom properties** as **design tokens** — components only reference `var(--bg)`, `var(--accent)`; a theme is a different set of values.

How it works

1. Define tokens on `:root`; override them under an attribute selector such as `[data-theme="dark"]`.
2. A small React **provider** (supplies a value to its subtree via context) stores the choice (`light` / `dark` / `system`), resolves `system` via the OS preference (`prefers-color-scheme`), and writes `<html data-theme="…">`.
3. CSS does the rest — no component re-renders to recolour.
4. Save the choice in `localStorage`, and apply it with a tiny inline script **before paint** to avoid a **flash of the wrong theme**.
5. Set CSS `color-scheme` so browser-drawn parts (form controls, scrollbars) match.

`code/theme.css` (tokens):

```
:root {
  --bg: #ffffff; --surface: #f6f8fa; --text: #1f2328; --muted: #59636e;
  --border: #d0d7de; --accent: #0969da; --accent-text: #ffffff;
}
[data-theme="dark"] {
  --bg: #0d1117; --surface: #161b22; --text: #e6edf3; --muted: #9198a1;
  --border: #3d444d; --accent: #4493f8; --accent-text: #0d1117;
}
body  { background: var(--bg); color: var(--text); }
.panel { background: var(--surface); border: 1px solid var(--border); border-radius: 12px; padding: 16px; }
.cta  { background: var(--accent); color: var(--accent-text); }
```

`code/theme.jsx` (the provider — the OS setting is an external store, so it uses `useSyncExternalStore`, §7.9):

```jsx
const ThemeContext = createContext(null);
const QUERY = '(prefers-color-scheme: dark)';

function subscribeSystem(cb) { const m = window.matchMedia(QUERY); m.addEventListener('change', cb); return () =>
m.removeEventListener('change', cb); }
function useSystemDark() { return useSyncExternalStore(subscribeSystem, () => window.matchMedia(QUERY).matches, ()
=> false); }

export function ThemeProvider({ children }) {
  const [choice, setChoice] = useState(() => localStorage.getItem('theme') ?? 'system'); // 'light' | 'dark' |
'system'
  const systemDark = useSystemDark();
  const resolved = choice === 'system' ? (systemDark ? 'dark' : 'light') : choice;

  useEffect(() => {                        // sync to the <html> element: CSS does the rest
    document.documentElement.dataset.theme = resolved;
    document.documentElement.style.colorScheme = resolved;   // native controls + scrollbars follow
    localStorage.setItem('theme', choice);
  }, [choice, resolved]);

  return <ThemeContext.Provider value={{ choice, resolved, setChoice }}>{children}</ThemeContext.Provider>;
}

export function useTheme() {
  const ctx = useContext(ThemeContext);
  if (!ctx) throw new Error('useTheme must be used inside <ThemeProvider>');
  return ctx;
}
// ThemeSwitcher renders three role="radio" buttons: light / dark / system
```

`code/04_theme_provider.jsx` drives it with a fake OS setting:

```
first visit (OS light)     choice=system resolved=light | <html data-theme="light"> | saved=system
OS switches to dark        choice=system resolved=dark | <html data-theme="dark"> | saved=system
user picks "light"         choice=light resolved=light | <html data-theme="light"> | saved=light
OS changes again (ignored) choice=light resolved=light | <html data-theme="light"> | saved=light
reload                     choice=light resolved=light | <html data-theme="light"> | saved=light
outside provider -> useTheme must be used inside <ThemeProvider>
```

The same page in Chrome with the OS in light and dark mode (`code/theme.html`, "system" selected):

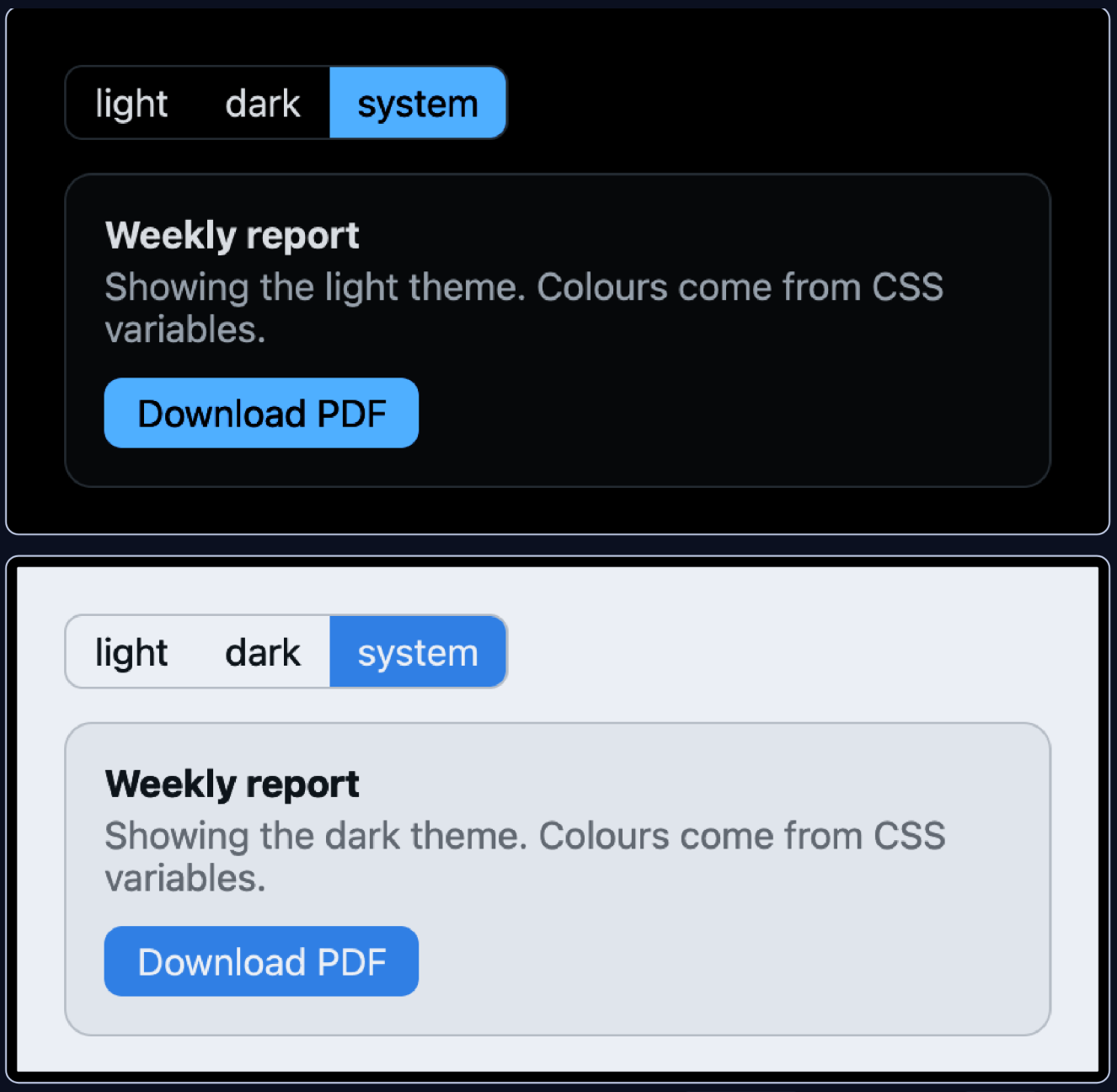


Figure 8.2 — One set of components, two token sets. Only the `data-theme` attribute on `<html>` differs.

Avoiding the flash

React runs after HTML and CSS are parsed, so a theme applied only in an Effect briefly shows dark-mode users the light page. `code/theme.html` uses a blocking script in `<head>`:

```
<script>
  try {
    const saved = localStorage.getItem('theme') || 'system';
    const dark = saved === 'dark' || (saved === 'system' && matchMedia('(prefers-color-scheme: dark)').matches);
    document.documentElement.dataset.theme = dark ? 'dark' : 'light';
  } catch {}
</script>
```

SSR frameworks need the same trick (`next-themes` injects it); a **cookie** (sent to the server with every request) lets the server render the right theme directly.

Alternatives and extras

- **CSS only**: without a manual toggle, `@media (prefers-color-scheme: dark) { :root { … } }` suffices — no JavaScript.
- `light-dark()`: with `color-scheme: light dark`, `color: light-dark(#111, #eee)` picks a value per scheme (Baseline since 2024 — supported in all major current browsers).

- **Tailwind**: `dark:` follows the OS by default; `@custom-variant dark (&:where(.dark, .dark *))` or a `[data-theme=dark]` selector makes it follow your toggle.
- **Component libraries** expose a `ThemeProvider` filling the same role (§8.9).
- **Why not colours in React context?** Every theme change would re-render every consumer; CSS variables recolour without rendering.

Common mistakes

- Hard-coded colours (`color: '#333'`) that ignore the theme — always use tokens.
- Reading `localStorage` during server rendering (it doesn't exist there) — read on the client or use a cookie.
- Only inverting colours: dark themes also need adjusted shadows, borders and less saturated accents, and must meet contrast ratios (WCAG 2.2 — Web Content Accessibility Guidelines — requires 4.5:1 for normal text).

TL;DR

Tokens as CSS variables, overridden by `[data-theme]`; a provider resolves light/dark/system and writes the attribute; a head script prevents the flash; `color-scheme` for native controls.

8.9 Component libraries

What it is

A **component library** provides ready-made, accessible components — buttons, dialogs, menus, date pickers, tables. Accessibility is the main reason: a correct dropdown menu needs focus management, keyboard navigation and ARIA roles (e.g. `role="menu"`, telling screen readers what a custom element is) that take weeks to get right (Chapter 14; HTML & CSS accessibility chapter).

Three kinds

Kind	What you get	Examples	Best when
Styled kits	Complete components with a design system (shared visual rules and components) and theming API	MUI (Material UI), Mantine, Chakra UI, Ant Design, React Bootstrap	Internal tools, admin panels, fast delivery, you accept their look
Headless (unstyled) primitives	Behaviour + accessibility, no styles — you bring CSS/Tailwind	Radix UI Primitives, React Aria (Adobe), Headless UI (Tailwind Labs), Base UI	A custom brand design that must still be accessible
Copy-in components	Source code copied into *your* repo (via a CLI), built on headless primitives + Tailwind	shadcn/ui	You want to own and edit the code, not depend on a package's API

How to choose

Question	Leans towards
Is there a designer with a custom design system?	Headless or copy-in
Do we need 50 components next week?	Styled kit
Are we using Tailwind?	shadcn/ui, Headless UI, Radix + Tailwind
Server Components / Next.js App Router?	Check the library's RSC guidance — many interactive components need `'use client'`
Bundle-size sensitive (public site)?	Headless + your CSS; import only what you use

Common mistakes

- Fighting a styled kit's design with overrides everywhere — pick headless instead.
- Mixing two styled kits (two resets, two themes, two button styles).
- Wrapping a library component so thinly that its API leaks everywhere — wrap it once in your own `<Button>` so you can swap later.

TL;DR

Styled kit for speed, headless for custom design with accessibility, copy-in (shadcn/ui) to own the code. Never hand-roll complex widgets without a reason.

8.10 Choosing an approach

Situation	Sensible default
New app, team likes utility classes and fast iteration	**Tailwind** + `clsx` / `tailwind-merge`, headless or shadcn/ui components
New app, team prefers writing CSS	**CSS Modules** + CSS variables for tokens
Content site with little interactivity	Plain CSS (with `@layer` and nesting) or CSS Modules
Existing styled-components/Emotion codebase	Keep it; consider zero-runtime or CSS Modules for new areas, especially if moving to Server Components
Design system shared across apps	Tokens as CSS variables + headless primitives; publish compiled CSS
Truly dynamic values (drag, progress, user colours)	Inline `style`, ideally setting a CSS variable

Whatever you choose: **one approach per codebase**, **tokens in CSS variables**, **components as the unit of reuse**, and **accessibility first** — never remove focus outlines without replacing them.

In the interview

> **30-second answer:** "React doesn't prescribe styling. Global CSS is simple but needs naming conventions; CSS Modules scope classes per file with zero runtime; Tailwind uses utility classes and generates only what I use; runtime CSS-in-JS like styled-components is convenient but adds render cost and doesn't fit Server Components, so zero-runtime tools are preferred now. Inline styles are for truly dynamic values. For theming I use CSS variables switched by a data attribute."

- *Dark mode?* — Tokens as CSS variables, `[data-theme=dark]` overrides, a provider for the toggle, a head script against the flash, `color-scheme` for native controls; no component re-renders needed.
- *CSS Modules vs Tailwind?* — Both scoped and zero-runtime; Modules keep CSS in CSS files with semantic names (`composes` reuses another class), Tailwind keeps styling in markup with a token scale. Team preference decides.
- *Does `import './Card.css'` scope the rules?* — No; imported CSS is global.
- *`style={{ zIndex: 2, width: 100 }}` ?* — `z-index: 2; width: 100px` .
- *Why `className`, not `class`?* — JSX compiles to JavaScript, where `class` is reserved, and it matches the DOM property `element.className`.

Chapter 8 TL;DR

Approach	Remember
Plain CSS	`className`; imports are global; BEM or layers for order
Inline `style`	camelCase object; numbers → px (except unitless); no `:hover`/media; for dynamic values
CSS Modules	`*.module.css`, `styles.x`; local names, `composes`, `:global`; zero runtime
Class composition	`clsx` / `cx`; accept `className`; variant maps
Tailwind v4	Utilities in JSX; only used classes generated; `@theme` tokens; no dynamic class names; `tailwind-merge` for conflicts
CSS-in-JS	Runtime (styled-components, Emotion) vs zero-runtime (vanilla-extract, StyleX, Panda); runtime is out of favour for new RSC apps
Theming	CSS variables + `data-theme`; provider for choice; head script against flash; `color-scheme`; `light-dark()`
Libraries	Styled kits vs headless vs copy-in (shadcn/ui); accessibility is the reason

Next: Chapter 9 — Routing and Data Fetching.